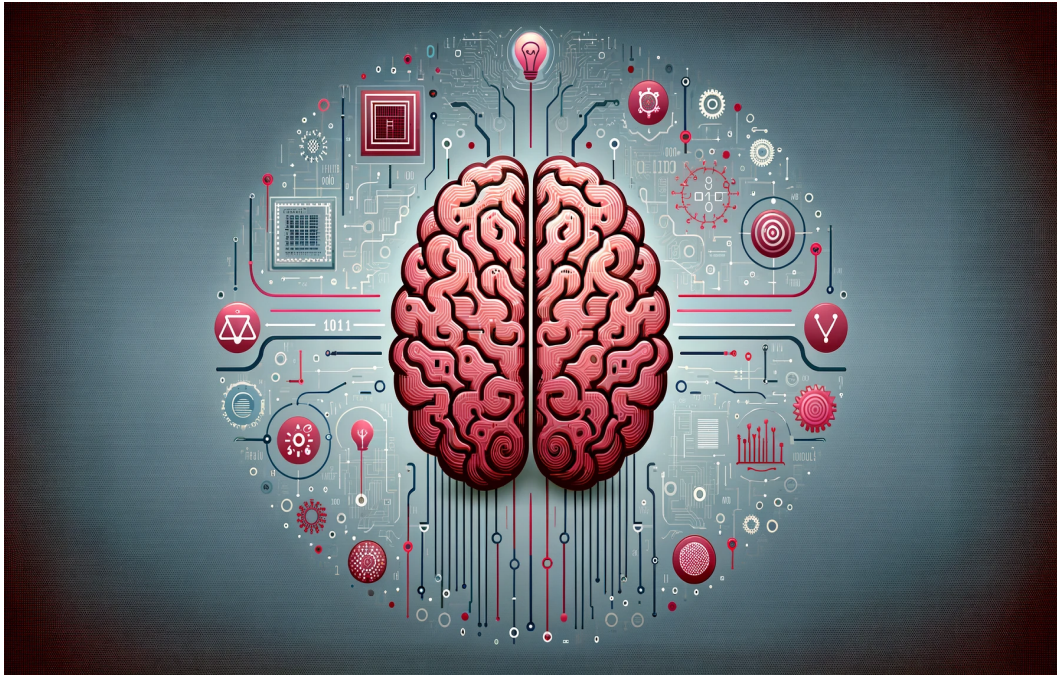




## Reducing Unconscious Bias at Work

Small assumptions. Big consequences. Better decisions start with awareness.

### What is unconscious bias?

Unconscious bias is the automatic mental shortcut our brains use to make quick judgments. It happens without intent — but it can still affect hiring, promotions, feedback, workload, inclusion, and wellbeing.

### Why this matters

- 1 Overlook talent
- 2 Distort performance evaluations
- 3 Reduce fairness in opportunities
- 4 Harm trust, morale, and retention
- 5 Affect real-world outcomes (including health and safety decisions)

## Real-World Bias Stories

### 1) The Surgeon Riddle

A father and his son are in a serious car accident. The father dies at the scene, and the son is rushed to hospital. In surgery, the surgeon says, "I can't operate on this boy. He's my son." Many people get stuck and search for complicated explanations, instead of the simple one: **The surgeon is the boy's mother.**

*Bias shown: Gender-role assumptions.*

### 2) CVs: "John" vs "Jane"

A hiring manager reviews two identical CVs: John Murphy and Jane Murphy. Without realizing it, they describe: • John: "strong fit, ambitious, leadership potential." • Jane: "a bit junior, may need time to grow." Nothing changed but the name.

*Bias shown: Gender bias in leadership perception.*

### 3) The "Culture Fit" Candidate

A woman of colour applies for Product Manager. Strong education, strong results. Panel feedback: "Very competent, but not sure she's a culture fit." No specific skill gap is identified. A male candidate who "felt easier" to the mostly similar team is preferred.

*Bias shown: Affinity bias disguised as culture fit.*

### 4) The Quiet Man and the "Natural Organiser"

In a mixed-gender team, recurring planning/admin tasks keep going to the same woman: • "She's a natural organiser." • "Great at note-taking." A quiet male colleague in the same role is rarely asked to do admin work and is instead praised for "strategic thinking."

*Bias shown: Gendered task allocation and visibility bias.*

### 5) The Patient Whose Pain Isn't Believed

Two patients with similar symptoms and pain: • White man: fast pain relief + tests • Black woman: "wait and see," concerns downplayed No conscious intent to discriminate — yet outcomes differ.

*Bias shown: Racial credibility bias.*

### 6) Performance Review: The "Likeable" Employee

Two high performers: • Employee A resembles the manager • Employee B does not A's mistakes are minimized; strengths amplified. B's minor issues are magnified.

*Bias shown: Affinity bias and halo effect.*

### 7) The Meeting Where the Idea Changes Owner

A junior woman shares an idea — little response. Later, a senior man repeats the same idea — "Great point!" Follow-up email credits him.

*Bias shown: Gender and seniority bias.*

### 8) The "Foreign-Sounding" Name in the Inbox

A manager notices they: • Respond quickly to familiar names • Delay or skim unfamiliar names The content quality is equal — response behaviour isn't.

*Bias shown: Name-based bias.*

## How teams can reduce bias (practical actions)

- 1 Use structured criteria: Define role requirements and scoring before interviews/reviews.
- 2 Blind what you can: Remove names and demographic clues in early screening where feasible.
- 3 Replace culture fit with values add: Ask what strengths or perspectives this person brings.